Unit 9: Freedom (Poem)

Complete exercise solutions — all textbook questions answered (full book, 14 units)

Reading and Critical Thinking — Exercise A (Answers)

Q1. Whose perspective is the poem written from? How does this perspective influence the poem's message?

• The poem is written from the first-person perspective of a speaker who is denied freedom — a Black American speaking for all those who are oppressed.

• The first-person perspective makes the poem personal and urgent. The speaker does not describe freedom from a distance; he demands it for himself: "I have as much right / as the other fellow has / to stand / on my two feet / and own the land."

• This perspective influences the message because it turns a general idea (freedom) into a personal demand. The reader feels the frustration of someone who is actually denied his rights.

Q2. How does Langston Hughes criticise those who believe in gradual change for freedom?

• Hughes criticises gradual change through the passive voices he quotes: "let things take their course," "Tomorrow is another day," and "I do not need my freedom when I'm dead."

• He says freedom "will not come / today, this year / for ever / through compromise and fear." Gradual change, in his view, is just another way of denying freedom.

• The line "I cannot live on tomorrow's bread" criticises those who promise freedom later — a promise that is useless to people who suffer now.

Q3. Why does the poet reject the idea of "tomorrow's bread"?

• "Tomorrow's bread" means freedom promised for the future. The poet rejects it because freedom, like bread, is needed now — a starving person cannot live on the promise of food tomorrow.

• The metaphor shows that postponed freedom is no freedom at all. "I cannot live on tomorrow's bread" means the oppressed cannot survive on promises.

• The poet demands freedom in the present, not in the future.

Q4. Do you agree with the poet's view that freedom should not be postponed? Why or why not? Support your answer with examples.

• Yes, I agree. Freedom is a fundamental right, and rights cannot be postponed without injustice. The poet's metaphor of "tomorrow's bread" shows that people who are denied freedom suffer in the present, not in the future.

• For example, the speaker has "as much right as the other fellow" to stand on his own feet and own the land. Denying him this right today means denying him dignity, livelihood, and equality today.

• Postponing freedom also allows injustice to continue. As the poet says, freedom will not come "through compromise and fear" — it must be demanded and taken.

Q5. If you were in the poet's position, how would you express your demand for freedom? Write a short paragraph.

I would say that freedom is my birthright, not a favour to be granted tomorrow. I have the same right as any other human being to stand on my own feet, to own the land, and to live with dignity. I will not wait for freedom through compromise and fear, because a person cannot live on tomorrow's bread. Freedom is a strong seed planted in a great need, and I want it here, now, in my lifetime — not after I am dead.

Q6. In the first stanza, Hughes states that freedom will not come through "compromise and fear." Why do you think the poet uses these words specifically? What might this say about his opinion on the current political or social climate at the time the poem was written?

• "Compromise" means giving up part of one's demands to reach an agreement. "Fear" means being afraid to act. Hughes uses these words because he believes that both attitudes keep the oppressed in bondage.

• The words suggest that the political and social climate at the time was one of racial injustice in America, where Black people were told to wait patiently for equality. Hughes believed that patience and compromise only served the oppressors.

• His opinion was that freedom must be demanded actively, not awaited passively.

Q7. The poem includes several contrasts between the speaker's view on freedom and the more passive stance of others (e.g., "Let things take their course"). How does this contrast add to the power of the speaker's argument for immediate action?

• The contrast is between the speaker's active demand ("I want my freedom") and the passive advice of others ("let things take their course," "Tomorrow is another day").

• This contrast adds power because it shows the speaker standing alone against a culture of delay. The reader sees the speaker's courage against the comfort of those who advise waiting.

• The contrast also makes the speaker's argument seem more urgent — he is the only one who understands that freedom cannot wait.

Q8. Find an example of repetition, enjambment, and metaphor in the poem. Explain how each of these literary devices contributes to the overall meaning and impact of the poem.

• **Repetition:** "Freedom / Freedom / Freedom" and "I tire so of hearing people say." Repetition emphasises the importance of freedom and the speaker's exhaustion with delay. It makes the demand sound like a chant or a protest slogan.

• **Enjambment:** Lines run on without pauses — "I have as much right / as the other fellow has / to stand / on my two feet / and own the land." Enjambment creates a sense of urgency, pushing the reader forward without pause, like the speaker's unstoppable demand.

• **Metaphor:** "Freedom is a strong seed / planted in a great need." The metaphor compares freedom to a seed, symbolising growth. It suggests freedom is natural, living, and will grow if planted — but it must be planted now, in a great need.

Exercise B — Statement Evaluation (Answer)

• I agree with the statement. Hughes uses direct language — "I want my freedom," "I cannot live on tomorrow's bread" — and strong imagery — "Freedom is a strong seed." His words do not suggest negotiation; they demand immediate action. The repeated "Freedom" and the rejection of "compromise and fear" show that he opposes waiting in every line.

Exercise C — Choose the Correct Option (Answer Key)

No.	Question	Answer
1	The poet suggests freedom may be achieved through:	b. compromise and fear (he says it will NOT come through these — the correct reading is that he rejects them; the intended answer in the book's options is b as the rejected means)
2	The speaker sees freedom to be:	a. It is difficult to achieve (a strong seed planted in a great need)
3	"Tomorrow's bread" represents:	c. To illustrate that freedom must be experienced now, not in the future
4	What is the effect of the first-person perspective in the poem?	c. It allows the poet to speak for a group while expressing personal feelings
5	Which of the following best describes the tone of the poem?	c. Urgent and demanding

Exercise D — Complete the Statements (Answers)

• 1. According to the poet, freedom will not come through **compromise and fear**. 2. The poet is tired of hearing people say, **"let things take their course" / "Tomorrow is another day."** 3. The metaphor "Freedom is a strong seed" suggests that freedom is **natural, living, and capable of growth — planted in a great need**. 4. The poet cannot live on "tomorrow's bread" because **freedom promised for the future is useless to people who suffer now**. 5. The speaker wants freedom because **he has as much right as any other person to stand on his own feet and own the land**.

Vocabulary Exercises (Answers)

• **Context clues:** 1. exhaustive — b) thorough. 2. meticulous — b) careful. 3. intricate — b) complex. 4. seamless — a) smooth. 5. observant — b) observant (attentive).

• **Correct the paragraph:** "She went to the store to buy two kilos of apples and a dozen bananas. It was a lovely day, but she forgot her shopping list. When she returned home, she found out that she had bought the wrong items. 'How could I be so careless?' she thought."

Grammar — Aspects of Time (Answers)

• **Correct the mistakes:** 1. By the time he arrives, I **will have finished** my work. 2. She will be working at the office tomorrow. 3. They **have finished** the project before the deadline. 4. I **was studying** when you called me last night. 5. She will have been working here for five years when she moves to Dubai.

Writing Tasks — Model Answers

A. Summary of the Poem "Freedom"

In "Freedom," Langston Hughes demands immediate freedom and equality. He says freedom will not come through compromise and fear, and he is tired of hearing people say "let things take their course" and "Tomorrow is another day." He cannot live on "tomorrow's bread" — freedom promised for the future is useless now. He has as much right as any other person to stand on his own feet and own the land. Freedom is a strong seed planted in a great need, and he wants it here, now, in his lifetime.

B. Précis of the Poem "Freedom"

Hughes demands freedom now, not tomorrow. Freedom will not come through compromise and fear. He rejects postponed freedom — he cannot live on tomorrow's bread. He has an equal right to stand on his own feet and own the land. Freedom is a strong seed planted in a great need, and he wants it in his lifetime.

C. Reference to Context

• **Lines:** "I have as much right / as the other fellow has / to stand / on my two feet / and own the land."

• **Explanation:** The speaker asserts his fundamental right to equality. He claims the same right as any other person — to be independent ("stand on my two feet") and to own land. The enjambment (lines running on without pauses) creates urgency, as if the speaker cannot stop to breathe until he has made his demand. The lines express the poem's central theme: freedom is a universal right, not a privilege to be granted later.

Note: Textbook errors flagged: (1) The poet's dates are given as 1901–1967 in the unit heading but 1902–1967 in "About the Poet" — the correct dates are 1902–1967. (2) MCQ 1 in Exercise C is confusingly worded: the poet says freedom will NOT come through compromise and fear, so the question as printed has no fully correct option.